

INDIAN DRONE STARTUPS

With the first regulations for commercial drone applications rolling out, many startups are vying to get in on the action.

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Due to no recommended regulations from the ICAO and a perceived security threat, the DGCA banned the use of drones in civil airspace on 7 October, 2014. However, only flying drones was illegal, not selling or buying them. Drones have been available in India for quite some time. Even consumer drone manufacturers such as DJI have an established presence in the country, with service centers in many cities. The day is finally on the horizon, when civilians can legally fly drones. The Ministry of Civil Aviation announced the first version of regulations for RPAS (Remotely Piloted Aircraft System) and they're set to come into effect from the 1 December 2018. Naturally, those with the entrepreneurial spirit are the most excited about this development. We reached out to a couple of them to hear what they had to say.

ABOUT THE REGULATIONS

You have already read about the regulations, but that might not paint the full picture, so let's hear what the startups in the country have to say. "It's a great first step by our government. I

believe most of these rules are reasonable. They should be open to amend the rules by constant communication with the drone community," says Prasanna Shevare of Drona Aviation, a startup that was founded in 2014 by a couple of bright minds from IIT Bombay.

Neel Mehta of Asteria Aerospace, has the same opinion but also a few concerns, "It is a welcome move for



Soon to be a thing of the past

the industry that the government has released regulations for operation of RPAS in the civil airspace. Some concerns of the industry with respect to operating height for RPAS have been alleviated. Use of a digital platform (Digital Sky) for application and issue of permissions is also forward thinking. However, the regulations calls for

multiple agencies to be involved for issuing operating permissions and it remains to be seen if the permissions can be issued in a timely manner." He also highlighted the cost of getting an operating permit which as of now stands at ₹25,000. Another concern of his was about the administration of the RPAS test sites. His concerns are certainly well placed. Startups need a fluid and responsive environment to work on their innovations. Apparently, the Government has already thought about this. "The government has appointed a task force to look into regulatory issues and to suggest updates to the regulations going forward, which is positive and signals that the government is open to change its thinking with time in this emerging industry," adds Neel.

"This is quite a significant development for civil aviation and a watershed moment for drone industry in India. With Digital Sky, India will pioneer to be a digital paperless regulation is a huge step," says Mrinal Pai of Skylark Drones. "The government is looking at a paperless system to register and apply for permission for both long-term large-scale enterprise drone applica-